

and thought that we have been pretty lazy. In the last 10-12 years, have we explored and secured new markets? Have we expanded the basket of products that we are exporting? We should now be aggressive, expand the basket of products, and look for new markets.

We should also look for opportunities for bilateral and multilateral trade agreements. I feel we made a mistake by walking out of RCEP (Regional Comprehensive Economic Partnership). Nevertheless, we should diversify our exports basket and markets now.

We should liberalise foreign direct investment. In the short term, we should incentivise exports by, may be, adjusting the exchange rate to compensate our exporters. Now, if this increases the cost of imports, we should cut down on all unnecessary imports such as foreign automobiles or Swiss watches.

The final thing that we should do is that we make it clear to the US that we will not bend, we will negotiate.



How do we negotiate? Should India be more flexible on, say, the agriculture and dairy front to secure deals like Japan and South Korea? What are our bargaining chips?

Our bargaining chip is our large consumer market.

No, we can't give up our policy on agriculture and dairy especially now when the number of workers in the primary sector, which is agriculture and dairy primarily, has risen by 4% under PM Modi. Roughly 45% of our workforce is in these sectors. Their contribution to the GDP may only be 15-17% but the number of people involved is larger than the US population. We can't jeopardise their lives and livelihoods.

Japan and South Korea

lead to more protectionism in the world?

The tariffs are definitely hurting globalisation. This is not the path on which the world should move. Tariff war means the WTO is dead, the rule-based world trade order is dead. Globalisation and its framework brought prosperity to the world in the last 15 years. Open economies have flourished more than the closed economies ever did. We should not undo all that hard and good

threatening to penalise India heavily for buying oil from Russia?

Do you see some geopolitical strategy or economic ideology at play here?

There are a few factors at play here outside of geopolitics and economics. First of all, President Trump is a man of strong likes and dislikes. He has prejudices. He is transactional and a friend of nobody.

Second, his family is in business with Pakistan's

“THE WORLD WILL NOT KEEP QUIET. COUNTRIES WILL BAND TOGETHER MINUS THE US, AND TAKE COUNTERMEASURES”

are developed markets and they export a lot more than us. They have also been liberalising their imports consistently because they can afford to. We can't. We have a large population to protect.

I also feel that, temporarily, we may impose stiff tariffs on selected American products while keeping them unchanged for the rest of the world. This will create entry barriers for the American products and their companies will take a hit.



Do you think President Trump's tariff war is hurting the idea of globalisation and may

work and I don't think the rest of the world will let it happen.

I agree that temporary protectionist measures can be taken to stave off a crisis but protectionism can't be elevated as the official economic policy of a country. Here, I feel that even the NDA government is a bit guilty of promoting protectionism by dressing it up under the garb of what they call “Atmanirbharta”. It has shades of protectionism even though it is projected as the idea of making the country self-reliant.



Why do you think the US is singling out and

Crypto Council. In fact, when Operation Sindoor was on, his sons and son-in-law were in Pakistan deliberating upon their crypto business.

Third, he claims that he brought the Pakistan-India conflict to an end. Pakistan has acknowledged it. Asim Munir (the current field marshal of Pakistan), apparently, has said that Trump should be given Nobel Peace Prize for bringing the war between India and Pakistan to end.

India, on the contrary, rebuffed Trump by saying that he had no role to play in the ceasefire. We have refused to bring tariff down on agriculture and